community’. The professor’s wife subsequently committed suicide.

But such tragedies have to be put in context, which is that in Kerala as elsewhere in India many Muslim communities live very much as Dalits lived in earlier times, isolated from the mainstream and constantly subjected to small provocations and threats. From time to time these provocations lead to retaliations that often escalate into wider violence in which the Muslim minority invariably comes off worst.

This is not a very reassuring note on which to end this brief foray into Islam in South India – but history should never be reassuring.